Bob Chapman turns hollow forms in birch ply

Birch

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BOB CHAPMAN

After teaching chemistry for many years, Bob took early retirement to become a professional woodturner, and is a member of the Register of Professional Turners. He was a demonstrator at the 2009 AWGB Woodturning Seminar and is available for commissions.

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Birch (*Betula pendula*) trees will thrive in a very wide variety of habitats and are fast growing, but relatively short lived – around 60–90 years, although some may survive to almost twice that age. They are well known as 'pioneer' trees and may often be found on the outer fringes of more mixed woodland, colonising open ground in advance of other trees. They are able to survive in poor soil because their deep roots find nutrients and they improve the soil when their leaves are eventually deposited on the soil surface and decompose. In this way birch trees prepare the ground for the later growth of other species.

An unusual form of birch is 'masur birch', which has very attractive dark brown markings, often giving a flame-like figure to the wood. The origin of the markings is a matter of debate, but one theory is that they arise when the tree heals itself from damage done to it by the Agromyzia Carbonara beetle whose larvae bore into the trees. Also known as Karelian birch from the province in Finland where it grows, it is quite rare and much sought after.

Birch trees do not generally grow to a great size

Birch trees rarely grow to any size, with trunks around 400mm diameter when mature and the timber has an even pale yellow or white colour with a fine straight grain. Although birch is not grown commercially in Britain, Scandinavian birch is used almost exclusively for furniture and for making plywood. Birch is surprisingly strong, being rated similar to oak (*Quercus robur*) and beech (*Fagus sylvatica*) for its strength and density. In England, birch was once used for making broomsticks, its bark was used in the tanning of leather and its sap can be used as a source of sugar and can be brewed into beer and wine.

There are several species of birch tree common to Britain, but possibly the best known and most easily recognised is the silver birch. Its attractive silver white stems and delicate leaves make it a favourite tree in parks, gardens and other public spaces.

The birch tree at the forefront of the bottom photo on this page, stands close to 'Lady Blantyre's Rock' in Bingley, Yorkshire. Lady Blantyre was the wife of Robert Walter Stuart, Lord Blantyre. She died in November 1875, aged 84 and her son in law, William Busfeild Ferrand erected this memorial to her in March 1876. He went on to become the Member of Parliament for Knaresborough and Devonport and showed genuine sympathy for the problems then facing the working man. He has the unusual distinction of being quoted by Karl Marx in *Das Kapital*.

The silver birch is the best known species

The birch by Lady Blantyre's Rock in Bingley

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